

BHUVAN BAM, GURFATEH PIRZADA, ROHIT SARAF AND PRATIBHA RANTA PLAY THE REVOLUTIONARIES

NIKHIL ADVANI RELISHES THE GRUELLING TASK OF CHRONICLING Indian history through long-format shows. The roster of his banner, Emmay Entertainment, of late is proof enough. There's one on the beginnings of India's space and nuclear programmes (*Rocket Boys*), another on the chaos before and in the immediate aftermath of India's independence (*Freedom at Midnight*), and a third on the rise of Mughal rule (*The Empire*). In his latest, though, Nikhil chose to take a lesser-treaded path; he wanted to have "fun" by making "an *Inglourious Basterds* version of the revolutionary chapter of India's battle for freedom". It meant that characters in the Amazon Prime Video show *The Revolutionaries*, namely Rash Behari Bose (played by Bhuvan Bam), Sachindra Nath Sanyal (Rohit Saraf), Bagha Jatin (Gurfateh Pirzada) and Pratibha Lahiri (Pratibha Ranta) will be seen singing and dancing at a Durga Puja celebration. It's one of the nine songs in the period action-drama.

In Nikhil's eyes, the four are a wild bunch whose untold stories need to be celebrated. "For them, it was as simple as 'we will just throw them [the British] out'," he says. "'They are shooting us, we will shoot them. We don't have weaponry, we will create it.'" The story of the carnage that the British unleashed after the 1857 mutiny, he notes, tends to be forgotten. The revolutionaries too, he feels, are quickly brushed over for the non-violent movements that followed—Non Cooperation, Quit India, Civil Disobedience.

For the filmmaker behind films such as *Kal Ho Naa Ho* and *D-Day*, it is important that today's youth goes beyond known names like Bhagat Singh, Rani of Jhansi and Mangal Pandey and get familiar with other seminal figures who pursued the quest for independence through violent means.

To make the show work, Nikhil knew he had to cast actors Gen Z would connect with. The inclusion of Bhuvan and Rohit instantly gives the show an audience. For Bhuvan, who knew little of Bose barring a few lines read in school textbooks, it was fascinating to witness such larger-than-life characters that he almost wondered '*yeh sahi mein hua tha* [Did it all really happen?]' "Of course, there are creative liberties, but the core of it is real," he says.

It's the pluck and vision they had at such a young age that wowed even Gurfateh. He noticed a bit of that revolutionary zeal in the Gen Z protests too. (Both Gurfateh and Pratibha were spotted at one in Mumbai). "People become lazy... *kaun ladega, bolega* [who will fight, speak up]," he says. "The Gen Z of today did that. They said, 'we have voices, we are educated, if we want something, we have the right to ask for it.'"

Both Bhuvan and Gurfateh speak of the responsibility that comes with playing legends who carry so much heft. "You hope that you don't go wrong with it," says Gurfateh. Apart from the reading material that came from Emmay, the actor embarked on his own research to know more about the man and his family. "I wanted to take it all in and get my own understanding of him [Bagha Jatin] and do my own thing with it," he adds, "while keeping the respect intact."

For Bhuvan, *The Revolutionaries* makes for not just engaging but also necessary storytelling. "In school we